were perceived to challenge the security status quo, that is, the case of Mohsin Dawar and Ali Wazir, two leading members of the Pashtun Tahafuz Movement (PTM). The PTM is a peaceful movement led by Manzoor Pashteen, a 25-year-old from South Waziristan, that is voicing its opposition to racial profiling of Pashtuns in the ongoing war against terrorism, demanding the return of the 'disappeared' and their rights under the Pakistani constitution; however, they have faced intimidation from the security state, where their supporters have been 'picked up', arrested and bullied in efforts to stop the movement. While the PTM is not a political party, its members, contesting from the districts of North and South Waziristan, won seats in the general elections for the National Assembly. Their role will be important in highlighting the plight of citizens in Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA), yet the space they will have to influence policy on FATA and Provincially Administered Tribal Areas (PATA) remains to be seen.

The decline of right-wing religious parties in this election was also a positive development, but one that needs to be assessed in relation to the success of the TLP, a political party that largely promotes an ideology of 'death to the blasphemer'. The TLP was the 'top fifth party' in 'the National Assembly, outranking major parties like Muttahida Qaumi Movement-Pakistan and Awami National Party among others' (Jahangir 2018). In Punjab, the TLP vote bank was about 69 per cent of the votes that were given to religious parties, while for the NA246 seat[4] in Karachi, the TLP candidate 'secured over 3,000 more votes than the PPP chairman'.

Ironically, these results are reflective of the nature of politics in Pakistan today as discussed in this book. The status quo remains with the security state in charge as parties such as the PML(N) have been removed from the playing field through the PTI; despite the decline of religious right-wing politics, the influence of the religious right has not completely dissipated, evident in the rise of the TLP, a political party that directly spews hatred and advocates violence; while the victory of members of PTM reflect the potential for change, of possibility, yet one that is defined in response to the atrocities of the security state – its narrative thereby shaped by the security narrative that has dominated the lives of Pakistanis for nearly seven decades.

A new political era – youth reflective politics?

PTI's election campaign, particularly in the urban centres, brought in a different middle-class demographic of young people, and families who were seldom seen in